

Peace Mission

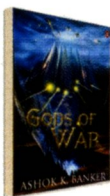
Armed with science as well as the Vedas, a novelist declares war on violence

By Geeta Doctor

Having chomped his way through the Ramayana, Ashok K. Banker descends upon us in a messianic mode. *Gods of War*, he explains in a forward, is the first of a projected series of five books. It's going to be a series to end all series, that is, if the world has not ended by then. For Banker is fearful about the fate of humanity. As he puts it in an author's note: "The only natural behaviour is peace. Apart from the moral, ethical and spiritual considerations, even from a logical and scientific point of view, it is inarguably the only viable long term stratagem for survival of any species, and on a holistic level, survival of a planetary ecosystem."

No one in his or her right senses would quarrel with such a proposition. Banker has been very circumspect in choosing five different points of view as his protagonists. One may not like them all, Santosh, the slum boy from Mumbai, has a tendency to scratch his backside in moments of stress, and use Marathi swear words. Ruth is a butch welder from New Jersey. Her vocabulary leaves much to be desired, she sweats a lot and lusts after her lesbian partner in a manner that suggests that Banker may have been watching too many B-grade flicks. He even includes a reference to "kaka hitting the punkah" that would make a 10-year old groan. No doubt that is why he takes a swipe at crabby critics of his oeuvre, who tend to find his style, lacking in just that, an elegance of expression. He may be taking arms against violence, but he has not found a way of using language or imagery in a way that conveys his thoughts with his meaning. There is a pair of Japanese twins, Akechi and Koshi, manga artists, who remain inscrutable, and Salimbhai, a Pakistani immigrant from Birmingham. The host for the current season is Ganesha, and to do Banker credit, he does a great job of bringing the elephant god to life as a twinkly English speaking pro-life spokesman.

There are some great set pieces of sci-fi moments. Some of them involve falling through tunnels in post-Lewis Carroll fashion, *Star War* turns of meta-monsters in metallic body suits of far superior technology than in those early days and a Rider Haggard like Superwoman who can actually become a pillar of fire as well as asides involving Banker's view on Scienecniks such as Dawkins and old Albert, who never gets his theorems totally right, without a touch of relativity. There are also reverential references to the inscrutable wisdom of the Vedas that lead one to imagine that this is how the series will be wrapped up with one large cosmic bang in which everyone will come "Om" to peace and shanti. ■



GODS OF WAR
by ASHOK K. BANKER
Penguin
Price: Rs 239
Pages: 282

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. *The Lost Symbol*
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
2. *Sidney Sheldon's Mistress of the Game*
Sidney Sheldon and Tilly Bagshaw, HarperCollins
3. *The White Tiger*
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. *Paths of Glory*
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
5. *The Winner Stands Alone*
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

1. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*
Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Dhewkar, Random House
3. *Jinnah: India Partition Independence*
Jaswant Singh, Rupa
4. *Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century*
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane
5. *The Idea of Justice*
Amartya Sen, Allen Lane

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
7. *Secrets & Lies*
Jaishree Misra, HarperCollins
8. *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

7. *A Better India A Better World*
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
10. *Amen: The Autobiography of a Nun*
Sister Jesme, Penguin
11. *The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma*
Gurcharan Das, Penguin

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